Urban Climate and Water

A watershed is an area of land where rain and streams drain to a common outlet. Stormwater runoff is rainwater that flows over roofs, roads, and other surfaces instead of soaking into soil. Green spaces and permeable ground can slow runoff and help reduce local flood risk. An urban heat island is a built-up area that is warmer than nearby rural areas, partly because pavement and buildings absorb and hold heat. Trees cool streets by providing shade and releasing water vapor through their leaves. Climate adaptation means adjusting communities and infrastructure to reduce harm from climate impacts that are already happening or expected. Examples include planting shade trees, improving drainage, and protecting areas that absorb floodwater.